



scratch. This facility always had 25 to 30 expatriates from South Korea. These expatriates trained Manish and others regarding processes, quality systems, production, 5S, and many other aspects. Manish thanks Rakesh Singh for whatever he is today. Singh, who took Manish's interview, was also his boss at the facility.

"I believe that your first boss plays a major role in defining the kind of leader you would be when your time comes. That is what happened to me also. Some of the past learnings and experiences coupled with the kind of leaders you work with, the kind of people you meet, make you what you are," he says.

Working in the corporate culture is no rocket science, but with cut-throat competition and ever-evolving business definitions, it many a times is one of the most difficult verticals to work in. You might have often heard professionals complaining about how their colleagues and bosses stole their idea. Manish, in his brilliantly on-going professional innings, has also headed Samsung's R&D team for colour televisions. Samsung was the place where Manish first heard and learned to practice what's referred to as "Success is all yours, failure is mine."

Manish first heard it from one of the managing directors of Samsung. When an MD was edged over by another company in terms of sales of colour TVs in India, Samsung appointed a new MD. The MD took over the office and called up a meeting of all the teams involved. The MD then asked the teams to collaborate to come up with a plan to counter the company that was outdoing Samsung's TV business. By the way Manish was only 29 when he was given the opportunity to head Samsung's R&D for colour televisions.

"Seven days passed just like that and nothing around the plan was ready. We made an absurd plan, and showed the same to the MD. We thought that the new MD would

disapprove of the plan instantly. But he approved the plan and said 'Success is all your guys, go out in the market and do the best you can, and failure is mine. If you fail, I will take the failure.' And he left the room."

Manish shared how the entire team sitting in the meeting room was left speechless. They had seen a guy who had complete faith in his team, a guy who was ready to take blame for all the failures. The team went to the drawing board again, created a new strategy, and executed the same in a successful manner.

"There I learnt how leaders should be. For me leaders are not like those who work on reports only. Leaders for me are people who empower people with the ability to take decisions and motivate you to execute plans. I think that is how people like me learn from everyday life. People around me do not know what I encountered yesterday and what I am going through today. I think everyone has an equal amount of capabilities. It is a matter of two things. First is pre-ordained and second is in line with the kind of people you meet. What kind of chances come to you and how you take those chances," he says.

Retirement, what retirement?

Today, Manish is known as one of the finest leaders in India. He is overseeing the entire operations of Panasonic and helping the team grow day by day. "I lead a very simple life. You will never see success riding on me. I try to maintain an open-door policy. I do not want to have a hierarchical structure. It should be like everybody is equal. Success and failures are a matter of time. I have seen so many ups and downs that you would see me behaving the same in almost every situation," he says.

The word retirement, as Manish says, is misunderstood by a lot of people. It might mean that Manish would not be into full-time responsibility as the time progresses. "If I

am fit, I would like to continue with full-time responsibility. I am reasonably clear that one day I would take the mentorship role and help companies and startups grow. I want to live life, learn from life, write, travel, and I would like to meet a lot of new people and understand new cultures," he shares his retirement plans.

He adds, "Everything that happens with you is an outcome of what you think and what you do. If your thinking is consistent and pure, and it is not for you but for people and society, things will happen to you."

What's Manish Sharma's vision for India?

"The kind of diversity, knowledge, and wisdom that India possesses is immense. I think we have not been able to provide our people with opportunities that are on an equal magnitude. I am not sure why we have not been able to do so. That is not in our hands, but what is in our hands is how soon and effectively we can catalyze this process from this point. I mean who had rich legacies like yoga, ayurveda, and a lot of other things. All four seasons are so rich. Tell me one country in the world which has so much diversity. I will try to catalyze the process even in the smallest manner possible. Helping develop new technology, bringing technology to India, helping people grab new opportunities, are some of the opportunities I think I can click," he shares.

Would Manish Sharma ever want to help the country formulate policies?

"I have great respect for the role that civil servants are playing today. I never thought of becoming an IAS officer but the last 10 to 12 years have allowed me to work closely with guys making policies. That is some fantastic work that they are doing. The more you are close to them, the more you understand the kind of hard work they are doing. Yes, I would want to be like bureaucrats," he answers. **EFY**